Where Every Film Was Shot

Filming locations of 23,468 films in Wikidata:
film cities, foreign productions and the James Bond films

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Abstract

Films are often shot somewhere other than where they come from or where they are set. I use Wikidata, the open knowledge base behind Wikipedia, to map the filming locations of every film it records with a located filming place: 23,468 films, 7,926 locations and 35,108 film-location pairs. Because 20% of those pairs name only a whole country and 14% only a state or region, I classify each location by level and map only cities, towns and sites, so that country centroids do not appear as filming hotspots. Grouping places with the nearest large city, Los Angeles (1,514 films), New York (1,350), London (1,118) and Paris (933) lead; Pinewood Studios is the single most used site (645 films). Comparing each location's country with the film's countries of origin, 19% of films were shot at least partly abroad. Canada hosts the most foreign productions (717, 95% of them American), while in Malta, Morocco, Bulgaria and Iceland foreign films are the large majority of all recorded filming. The share of films shot abroad rose from 20% in the 1950s to 25% in the 2000s (excluding Indonesia). The 25 Eon James Bond films have 248 recorded locations in 36 countries and territories, but recent films are far better documented than early ones. Coverage is strongly biased towards American and well-known films: 40% of films are American, and the most popular films have nearly three times as many recorded locations as the least known.

Keywords: film; filming locations; runaway production; film geography; James Bond; Wikidata; open data; mapping

1 Introduction

Where a film is shot is an economic decision as much as an artistic one. Studios cluster in a few production centres, and since the 1950s producers have followed lower costs, tax incentives, skilled crews and landscapes to other countries, a pattern known in the United States as runaway production (Miller et al., 2005; Goldsmith and O'Regan, 2005). Some places, Toronto, Budapest, Malta or the Moroccan desert, have built industries on standing in for somewhere else (Scott, 2005).

That geography is usually studied through case studies, trade data or production surveys. Wikidata (Vrandečić and Krötzsch, 2014) offers another, open view: it records a filming location (property P915) with coordinates for tens of thousands of films, together with each film's release dates and countries of origin. This paper uses one query of that record to ask four questions. Which places are filmed most? Which countries host other countries' productions, and has that changed by decade? Which cities are filmed mostly by foreign productions? And how do the James Bond films, the archetypal globe-trotting series, look in the data? An interactive map accompanies the paper (https://maps.tristanhotham.com/film-locations/).

The contribution is descriptive, and the main finding about the data is its unevenness. I am explicit about coverage throughout: the record is a map of documented filming, not of filming.

Table 1: From query to data.

Step	Count
Rows returned by the query	119,808
Films	23,468
with a year	22,271
with a country of origin	23,240
with at least one city, town or site (mapped)	14,901
Filming locations	7,926
countries / regions / cities and towns / sites	151 / 465 / 891 / 6,419
Film-location pairs	35,108
naming a country / region / city or town / site	6,926 / 5,038 / 13,094 / 10,050

2 Data

The data come from one QLever (Bast and Buchhold, 2017) query of Wikidata in 2026: every item that is an instance of film (Q11424) with a filming location that has coordinates (P625), with the film's English label, publication dates (P577), countries of origin (P495) and number of sitelinks, and each location's label, coordinates and country (P17). The result has 119,808 rows, because a film repeats for every combination of date, origin and location country. Table 1 shows how this reduces to films and locations. Country outlines, first-level divisions and populated places come from Natural Earth (Natural Earth, 2026).

3 Methods

3.1 Records

I keep one record per film and per location. A film's year is its earliest publication year; 22,271 films have one. 1,979 have no English label and are identified by their Wikidata ID. Directors (P57), from a second query, are used only for labels on the interactive map.

3.2 Location levels

Each location is assigned a level. It is a *country* if its Wikidata ID is that of a Natural Earth country, a UK nation, a former state or a continent; a *region* if it is a Natural Earth first-level division (matched by Wikidata ID or by name within the same country) or one of a short list of large named areas (French and Italian regions, big islands); a *city or town* if its English label matches a Natural Earth populated place within 40 km; otherwise a *site*, which includes studios, streets, buildings, parks, villages and small islands. Small territories under 1,500 km^2 (Hong Kong, Malta, Monaco, Singapore and others) count as cities, because their centroid is close to everywhere in them. Country and region locations are counted in all country-level figures but are never mapped as points. A location's country is the present-day country its point falls in.

3.3 Home and abroad

A film is shot abroad at a location if the location's country is not one of the film's countries of origin. Co-productions are at home in every partner country; films of the Soviet Union, Yugoslavia and Czechoslovakia are at home in any successor state; and crown dependencies and overseas

territories count as home for the United Kingdom, the United States, France, the Netherlands and Denmark. 228 films with no country of origin are excluded. Indonesia needs separate treatment: 3,017 films (13% of all) list the single location "Indonesia", 99% of them Indonesian, so I report shares both with and without Indonesian films.

3.4 Film cities and popularity

For city rankings, every city, town or site is grouped with the nearest Natural Earth populated place of at least 250,000 people within 32 km, so that Pinewood Studios counts for London and Santa Monica for Los Angeles. Popularity is the number of Wikidata sitelinks (Wikipedia articles in any language and other Wikimedia pages), a rough measure of how widely a film is known. Popularity-weighted counts sum the sitelinks of the films at a place.

3.5 James Bond

The 25 official films made by Eon Productions, from Dr. No (1962) to No Time to Die (2021), were identified by a hand list of Wikidata IDs, each checked against title and year. The 1967 Casino Royale, not an Eon production, is excluded.

4 Results

4.1 Where films are shot

Figure 1 shows the 14,901 films with at least one mapped place (63% of all). The pattern is dense in western Europe and the United States, thinner across Asia and Latin America, and almost empty across Africa, a first indication of coverage.

Grouped into cities (Figure 2), Los Angeles has 1,514 films, New York 1,350, London 1,118, Paris 933 and Vancouver 452; the top five account for 34% of films with a mapped place. Weighting by popularity leaves the top five unchanged but moves places further down: Long Beach rises from 23rd to 9th, while Hong Kong falls from 7th to 17th and Ooty, a hill town in Tamil Nadu with 199 almost entirely Indian films, to 44th. The most used single site is Pinewood Studios (645 films); 66 locations are named as studios or stages and appear 881 times.

4.2 Home and abroad

Of 23,239 films with an origin and a located place, 4,329 (19%) were shot at least partly abroad, 21% excluding Indonesian films; 2,968 were shot only abroad. Table 2 and Figure 3 show the host countries. Canada hosts 717 foreign films, 95% American, and is followed by the United States (292), the United Kingdom (287), France and Spain. In proportion, Malta (96%), Morocco (82%), Bulgaria (79%) and Iceland (78%) are filmed mostly by others. Large producers mostly stay home: only 4% of films shot in the United States are foreign. Leaving home is commoner for British (32%) and Indian (35%) films than for American (25%) or French (21%) ones.

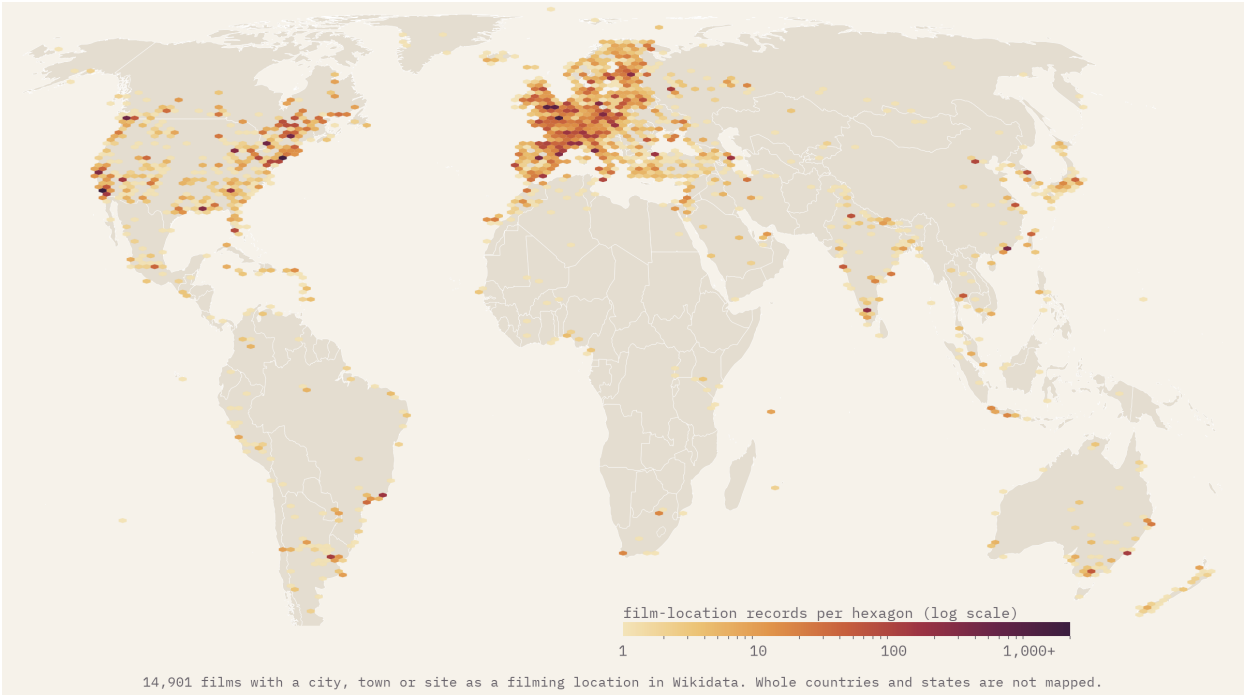


Figure 1: Filming locations in Wikidata: film-location records per hexagon (cities, towns and sites only), Equal Earth projection.

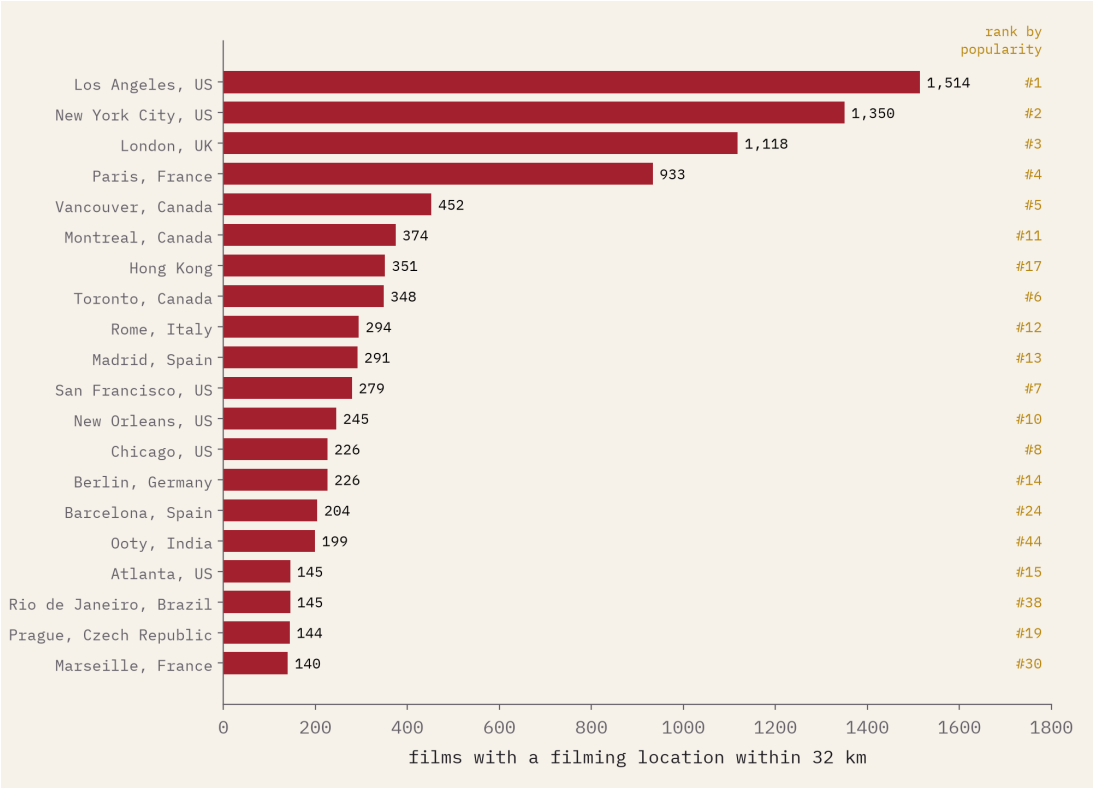


Figure 2: The twenty filming cities with most films, and (right, gold) their rank when films are weighted by sitelinks.

Table 2: Countries hosting most foreign productions: films with a known origin shot there, foreign productions, share, and main origins.

Country	Films	Foreign	Share	Main origins
Canada	2,167	717	33%	United States 683, United Kingdom 56
United States	6,959	292	4%	France 67, Italy 46
United Kingdom	1,362	287	21%	United States 208, India 31
France	1,719	253	15%	United States 138, United Kingdom 61
Spain	1,064	252	24%	United States 122, United Kingdom 75
Mexico	362	182	50%	United States 159, France 18
Italy	912	161	18%	United States 92, United Kingdom 37
Thailand	161	141	88%	United States 63, India 25
Morocco	159	131	82%	United States 62, France 44
Czech Republic	308	120	39%	United States 63, Germany 27
Switzerland	183	113	62%	United States 41, France 24
Bulgaria	137	108	79%	United States 76, Germany 16
Germany	591	102	17%	United States 55, France 17
New Zealand	225	97	43%	United States 55, India 20
Austria	167	92	55%	United States 36, Germany 34

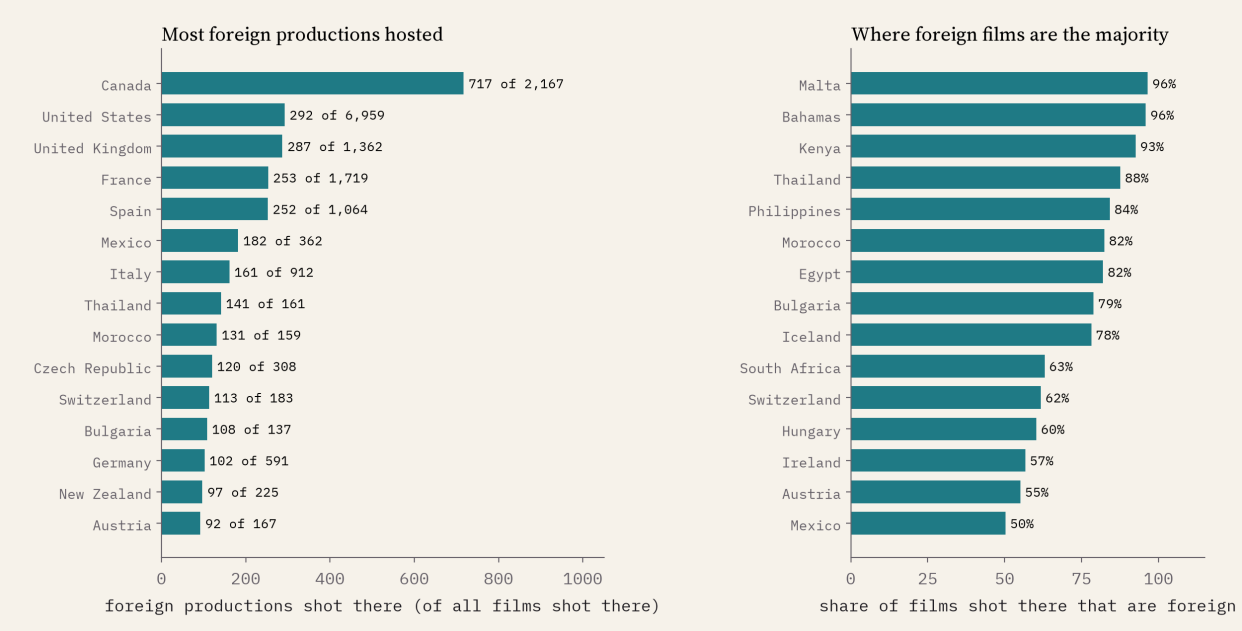


Figure 3: Left: the fifteen countries hosting most foreign productions. Right: share of films shot in each country that are foreign, for countries with at least 40 films with a known origin.

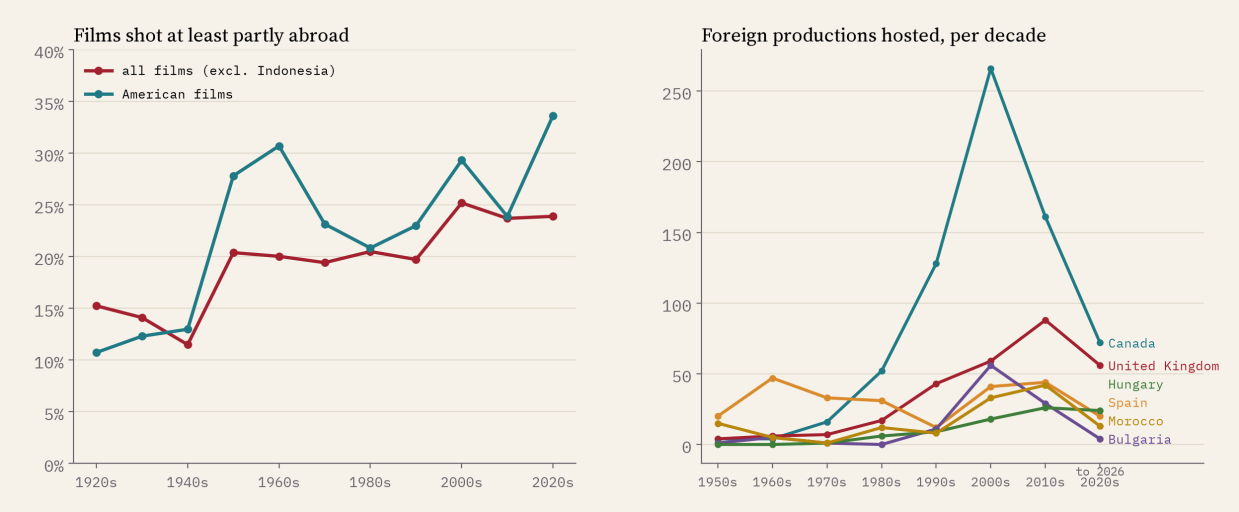


Figure 4: Left: share of films shot at least partly abroad, by decade. Right: foreign productions hosted per decade by six countries.

4.3 Change by decade

The share of films shot abroad rose from 20% in the 1950s to 25% in the 2000s and 24% in the 2010s (Figure 4). American films travelled early: 31% of those from the 1960s were shot partly abroad. What changed more is the destination. Foreign productions in Spain peak in the 1960s, the era of European co-productions and westerns shot in Almería; Canada's in the 2000s, Bulgaria's in the 2000s and Hungary's and Iceland's in the 2010s. The 2020s run only to 2026 and are incomplete.

4.4 Stand-in cities

Among cities with at least 25 films with a known origin, foreign productions dominate in Valletta (96%), Bangkok (85%), Budapest (66%), Vancouver (63%) and Toronto (56%) (Figure 5). These are the cities known as stand-ins, but the data cannot confirm what they stood in for, since narrative location (P840) is not in the query. Several big host countries are recorded mostly at country level: 227 films were shot in New Zealand, but only 3 at a place in Wellington and 8 in Auckland.

4.5 James Bond

The 25 Eon films have 248 recorded locations, 179 distinct, in 36 countries and territories (Figure 6, Table 3). Pinewood Studios is listed for 22. After the United Kingdom the commonest countries are the United States (10 films) and Switzerland, Italy and the Bahamas (6 each). Documentation grows over time: films before 1990 average 6.6 locations, those since 2006 19.6; Spectre has 33 and Licence to Kill 2.

4.6 Coverage

The films come from 134 countries, but 40% are American and 13% Indonesian. India, the world's largest producer of feature films by number, has 614; China 197; Nigeria 13. Popular films are described in more detail: films with fewer than five sitelinks average 1.3 locations and 10% were shot abroad, films with 50 or more average 3.6 and 44% (Figure 7). 78% of films have a single recorded location.

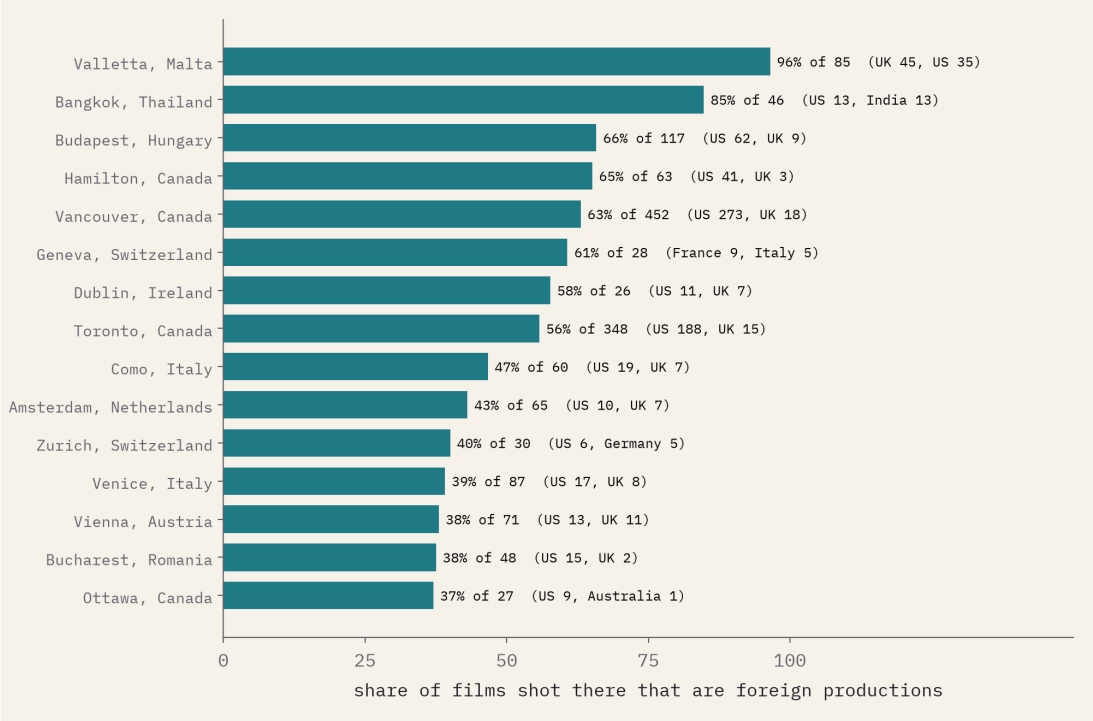


Figure 5: Cities where foreign productions are the largest share of recorded filming, with the two commonest origins.

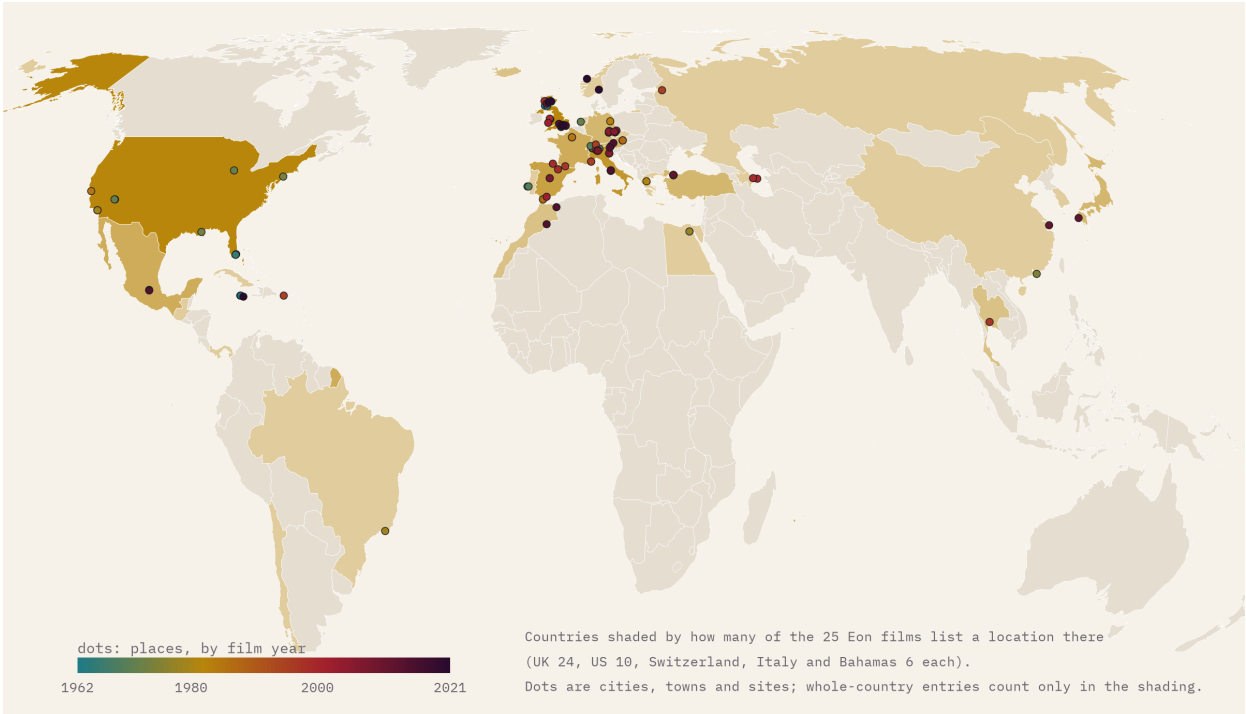


Figure 6: Filming locations of the 25 Eon James Bond films in Wikidata.

Table 3: The 25 Eon James Bond films: recorded locations, whether Pinewood Studios is listed, and countries outside the UK.

Year	Film	Places	Pinewood	Outside the UK
1962	Dr. No	4	yes	Jamaica
1963	From Russia with Love	18	yes	Switzerland, Spain, Italy, Turkey
1964	Goldfinger	8	yes	Switzerland, United States
1965	Thunderball	5	yes	Bahamas, France, United States
1967	You Only Live Twice	5	yes	Bahamas, Spain, Japan
1969	On Her Majesty's Secret Service	12	yes	Switzerland, Portugal
1971	Diamonds Are Forever	9	yes	Germany, Netherlands, United States
1973	Live and Let Die	3	yes	United States
1974	The Man with the Golden Gun	3	yes	Hong Kong, Thailand
1977	The Spy Who Loved Me	6	yes	Bahamas, Switzerland, Egypt, Japan
1979	Moonraker	7	yes	Brazil, Guatemala, Italy, United States
1981	For Your Eyes Only	5	yes	Bahamas, Greece
1983	Octopussy	5	yes	Germany, United States
1985	A View to a Kill	6	yes	Switzerland, France, Iceland, United States
1987	The Living Daylights	8	yes	Austria, Morocco, United States
1989	Licence to Kill	2		Mexico, United States
1995	GoldenEye	13		Switzerland, France, Monaco, Puerto Rico, Russia
1997	Tomorrow Never Dies	6	yes	Germany, France, Mexico, Thailand
1999	The World Is Not Enough	17		Azerbaijan, Bahamas, Spain, Turkey
2002	Die Another Day	8	yes	Cuba, Spain, Iceland, South Korea, United States
2006	Casino Royale	29	yes	Bahamas, Czech Republic, Italy
2008	Quantum of Solace	8	yes	Austria, Chile, Spain, Italy, Mexico, Panama
2012	Skyfall	16	yes	China, Japan, Turkey
2015	Spectre	33	yes	Austria, Italy, Morocco, Mexico, Vatican City
2021	No Time to Die	12	yes	Italy, Jamaica, Norway

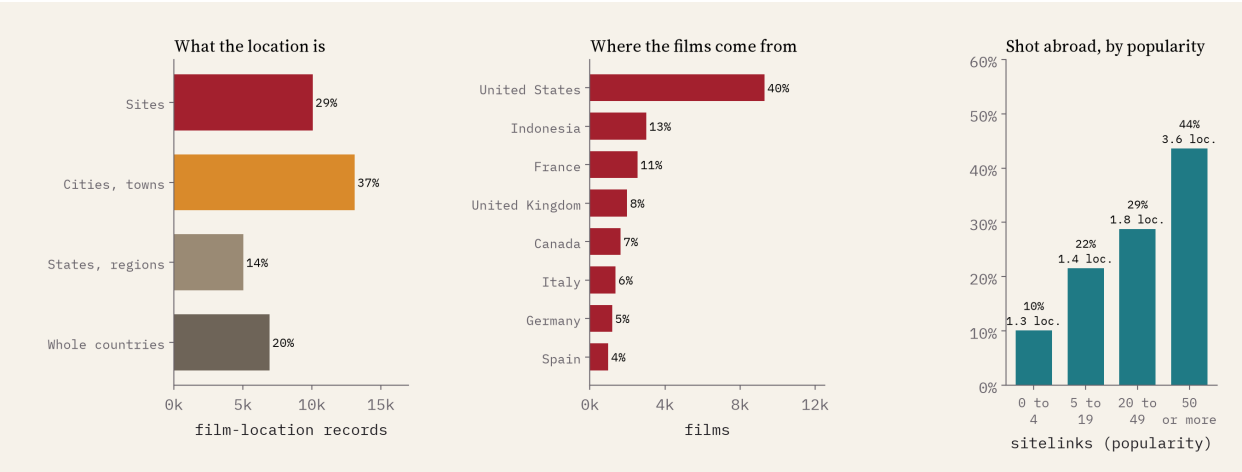


Figure 7: Coverage: film-location records by level; films by country of origin; share shot abroad and mean recorded locations by popularity.

5 Discussion

Three features of the open record stand out. First, the concentration of filming in a handful of production cities, with Los Angeles, New York, London and Paris far ahead, matches what studies of film industry clustering would predict (Scott, 2005). Second, the host-country pattern reflects the economics of runaway production: Canada's large count, overwhelmingly American, and the late rise of Bulgaria and Hungary are consistent with the role of tax incentives and studio building (Miller et al., 2005; Goldsmith and O'Regan, 2005). Third, and most important for interpretation, the record is shaped by who documents films. The rise in films shot abroad is partly a rise in recorded detail, as the Bond films show: earlier films travelled, but fewer of their locations have been entered.

6 Limitations

First, Wikidata's filming locations are incomplete and skewed to American, English-language and well-known films; totals count documented films, not films. Second, a third of film-location records name only a country or region; these are kept for country figures but cannot be mapped, so the point map understates places such as New Zealand and Morocco. Third, the level classification is rule based and will misclassify some locations, for example large islands treated as sites. Fourth, home and abroad depend on Wikidata's countries of origin, which for co-productions may list many countries and for others may be missing. Fifth, the data say nothing about setting, time on location or budget. Sixth, sitelinks measure Wikimedia attention, not audiences. Finally, all counts refer to one retrieval in 2026.

7 Conclusion

One open query is enough to draw a world map of filming, rank the film cities, show which countries host other countries' films and follow James Bond around the world. Its gaps are part of the result: the map shows where filming has been documented, and the interactive version lets readers see both.

Data and code availability

The interactive map is at https://maps.tristanhotham.com/film-locations/. Data and code are at https://github.com/Tristan-Hotham/film-locations and archived with this paper at https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.23847354. Derived data are released under CC BY 4.0 and code under the MIT licence.

AI statement

I wrote the text, with drafting and editing assistance from Claude (Anthropic), which also helped prepare the analysis code. I reviewed and checked all text and results.

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